Mistakes can delay or prevent the proper achievement of the objectives of individuals and organizations, but a visionary like Prof. Sarabhai can use errors as opportunities to promote innovation and the development of new ideas. He was not especial y concerned with the mistake in the timer circuit, least of al with pinning the blame for it. Prof. Sarabhai's approach to mistakes rested on the assumption that they were inevitable but general y manageable. It was in the handling of the crises that arose as a consequence that talent could often be revealed. I later realised by experience, that the best way to prevent errors was to anticipate them. But this time, by a strange twist of fate, the failure of the timer circuit led to the birth of a rocket engineering laboratory.

It was my usual practice to brief Prof. Sarabhai after every Missile Panel Meeting. After attending one such meeting in Delhi on 30 December 1971, I was returning to Trivandrum. Prof. Sarabhai was visiting Thumba that very day to review the SLV design. I spoke to him on the telephone from the airport lounge about the salient points that had emerged at the panel meeting. He instructed me to wait at Trivandrum Airport after disembarking from the